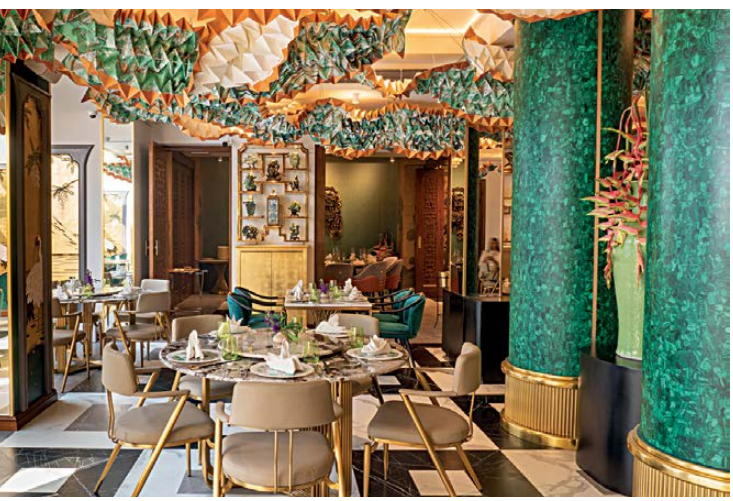
There are restaurants where people go to eat. And then there are restaurants where the restaurant itself is part of the occasion.

India's greatest five-star dining rooms have been much more than addresses on a hotel's restaurant list. Apart from hosting diplomatic dinners, closing business deals, offering first date venues, family celebrations and celebrity sightings, they have introduced generations of Indians to new cuisines, turned humble ingredients into objects of desire, and transformed individual dishes into culinary signatures.

Some have been around for half a century; others, possibly a little younger, but what connects them is not simply longevity. It is something that is harder to manufacture: memory. A sense of place. A particular table. A dish that tastes exactly as it did years ago. A maître d' who remembers your name. A dining room associated with a milestone. A recipe that survives generations. A ritual that refuses to disappear.

From the wood-fired tandoors of Bukhara and the slow-cooked Awadhi cuisine of Dum Pukht at ITC Maurya to the theatrical European journey of Orient Express at Taj Palace and the pioneering Sichuan cooking of Golden Dragon at The Taj Mahal Palace, these restaurants have helped define what luxury dining in India means. Their stories are not simply about food. They are about people, power, hospitality, craftsmanship and the magic of a table that people remember long after the meal is over.

Over the decades, these tables have borne witness to India's changing tastes and, in many ways, have helped shape them. Behind every famous dish is a story; behind every dining room, a generation of memories and moments. This is the story of 10 restaurants that didn't simply serve India's luxury diners—they became part of their lives.





Jade, The Claridges, New Delhi—1983

The Chinese Table that Delhi Remembers

Some restaurants become famous because of one dish. Others become institutions because of the people who sat around their tables. Jade at The Claridges belongs to the latter category. For years, it was part of Delhi's vocabulary of Chinese fine dining—Cantonese cooking, elegant service and the enduring old-world glamour of Lutyens' Delhi.

Jade's recent transformation has brought a refreshed dining room and contemporary interpretation of its menu while retaining its Chinese-Cantonese identity and dim sum tradition. That balance matters because nostalgia alone is not enough to sustain a restaurant. A legacy restaurant must know what not to change—and what absolutely must change. And perhaps that is why the social history of Jade is more interesting than any single dish. It belongs to a generation of restaurants where the table mattered as much as the food.

Signature: Cantonese cuisine, dim sum and Chinese classics

The Jade lesson: Legacy is not about preserving everything. It is about preserving what matters.

Meal for Two ₹7,000 plus taxes